



“EVEN DEATH IS NOT TO BE FEARED BY ONE WHO HAS LIVED WISELY”

Gautama Siddharta (Buddha), 563–483 BCE

482 THE NUMBER OF YEARS OF THE ROMAN REPUBLIC

kingdoms. Of these, Magadha was the most important state. Afterward, Darius subdued most of the Greek city-states of Ionia, before he **crossed into Europe** in 513 BCE to conquer Thrace.

In Italy, Servius Tullius (r. 578–534), the **sixth king of Rome** and said to be a former slave, had succeeded Tarquinius Priscus in 578 BCE. During his reign he implemented **important reforms**, fixing the formal boundaries of the city by dividing the Romans into four “tribes,” a system that would be extended as Roman territory grew, and also into classes that were **graded by wealth**. The population was divided by what equipment they could afford and what role they played in the Roman army. The wealthiest class fought as cavalry, the higher classes as heavy infantry, and the poor as light auxiliary troops. The votes of the richer classes carried much greater weight in the popular assembly. **The last king of Rome**, Tarquinius Superbus (r. 534–509 BCE) was an Etruscan. Concerned at the **growing tyranny** of his rule, a group of

Roman aristocrats led by Lucius Junius Brutus and Lucius Tarquinius Collatinus (the king’s cousin) won over the army and barred the gates of the city to the king, who was deposed. The coup leaders then **established a republic** in which supreme authority was held by two magistrates called **consuls**. The power of the consuls was limited by the fact that **new**



CYRUS THE GREAT
(r. 559–539 BCE)

Little is known about the early life of Cyrus. He was the ruler of the kingdom of Pars when he led a revolt against his Median overlord Astyages. By defeating Astyages, Cyrus became king of the Medes. He then continued to expand Persian influence with the conquest of Lydia. Cyrus adapted local ideas about kingship to cast himself as an ideal ruler in the cities he conquered. Cyrus died in 539 BCE.

consuls were elected by the popular assembly each year.

Some time around 530 BCE, **Gautama Siddharta**, a Hindu prince of Kapilvastu (now in Nepal), had a religious revelation and rejected his noble upbringing to embark on a quest for “enlightenment.” Six years later he received it and began to preach a way of moderate asceticism to gain release from the suffering of

material life. He is known as the Buddha (which means the “awakened one” in Sanskrit), and his followers, who became known as **Buddhists**, spread his ideas throughout South Asia and, in the late 3rd century CE, into China and thence to Korea, Japan, and Southeast Asia.

Confucius (or Kong Fuzi) was born around 551 BCE, in a period of political instability during China’s

Spring and Autumn period. From the age of 15 he devoted himself to scholarship, and the **political philosophy** he developed reflects the turbulent times. He taught that the righteous man (or junzi) must have regard to others and **inflict no unnecessary harm**. His philosophy, as developed by his disciples, taught respect for elders and became a cornerstone of the later imperial system.



Persian elite

These archers from the palace of Darius at Susa were the elite of the Persian army, which included representatives from provinces as far off as Ethiopia and Afghanistan.

